RELAY

VERSION 2.0

USER GUIDE

Gold, traded with discipline.

Relay is a fully automated Expert Advisor for XAUUSD. It never runs a grid or a martingale, sends a stop loss with every trade, and shows on the chart what it is doing and why. This guide covers everything from the first attach to what a bad month looks like.

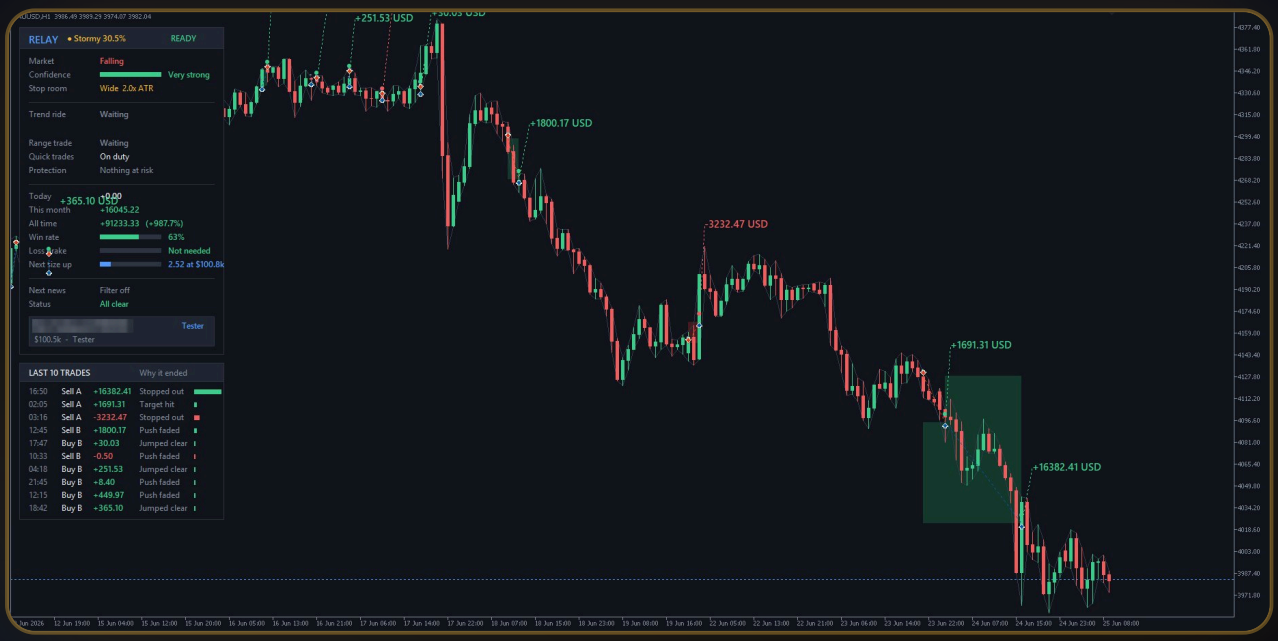
One trend position at a time

A **stop loss** on every trade

No grid, no martingale

Three engines

Prop firm mode



Relay in the Strategy Tester, visual mode: the live dashboard on the left, and every closed trade drawn on the chart where it happened. Account details blurred.

824	62.3%	1.66	+121,447	29.6%
trades	closed in profit	profit factor	USD on 10,000	

				max equity drawdown

Backtest, 1 Jan 2025 to 29 Sep 2026, IC Markets real ticks, default settings, which are **very high risk settings**. Not a live result. The good and the bad case in full.

INTRODUCTION

Gold is not the market it was ten years ago.

Since 2024 and 2025 gold has moved in long, violent, news-charged waves, a regime that punishes robots built on the calm ranges of the last decade. Relay was built the other way around: designed, tuned and validated on the modern market first, using real tick data, with its protections set for the days the market stops cooperating.

Inside, three engines share one account. A trend engine rides the big waves with an adaptive trail, a fast engine banks short bursts, and a quiet-market engine works the hours in between. The measured condition of the market decides which of them may act.

No strategy works forever, and anyone who promises otherwise is selling a story. An edge belongs to a market regime, not to the laws of nature. Relay's edge was measured on gold from 2025 onward. If that regime changes, the results will change with it, and Relay will be re-validated for the new one. Every number in this guide is a test measurement under stated conditions, including the losing ones.

The developer

START HERE

Install and first attach

Five minutes, and nothing to load: the tested configuration is compiled in.

1. **Open an XAUUSD chart**, under whatever name your broker gives gold, on any timeframe. Relay reads the timeframes it needs by itself.

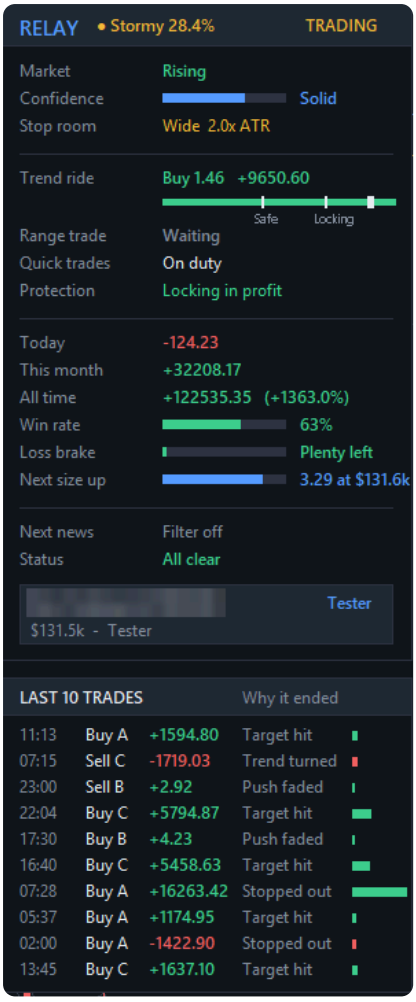
2. **Attach Relay.** Every default you see in the dialog is the tested value, so on a fresh chart there is nothing to change. If you ran an earlier version of Relay, press **Reset** in the Inputs tab first: MetaTrader keeps the old values otherwise.
3. **Enable Algo Trading** in the terminal and allow it in the EA's Common tab. The dashboard appears within seconds.
4. **Check the dollar gauge.** Relay reads your broker's EURUSD as a dollar-confirmation gauge and finds its name by itself. If the Experts log says the dollar dial is off, your broker names it with a suffix or prefix (EURUSD.r, EURUSDm and so on): type that exact name into *Dollar gauge symbol*.
5. **Leave it alone.** One chart, and nothing else trading the account: no manual trades on the same symbol and no second EA beside it.

> **Upgrading?**
> The tested configuration lives inside the EA, not in a side file. Upgrading is the one moment that needs care: press **Reset** in the Inputs tab, because MetaTrader silently carries your old values into the new version.

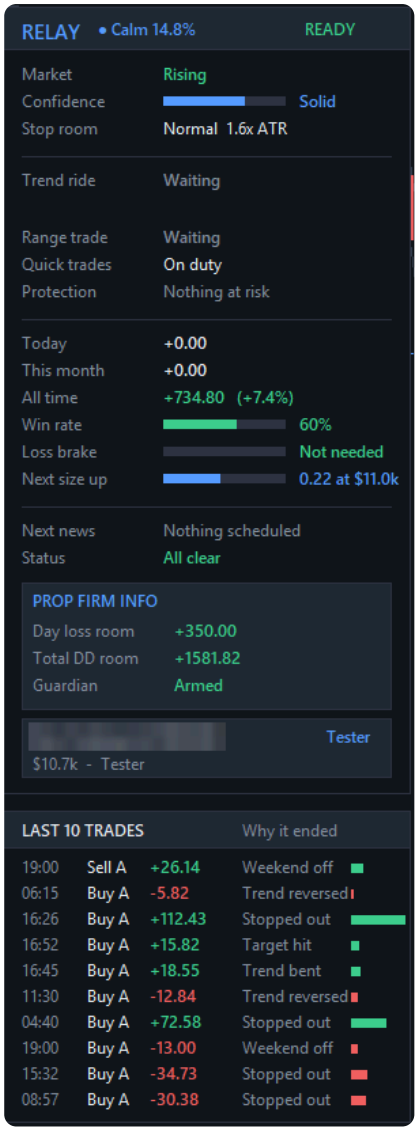
START HERE

The dashboard

Everything Relay knows, in plain words, on the chart.



A retail account riding a trend. Account details blurred.



Prop firm mode: the firm's limits, counted down.

Top line

The regime chip, Calm or Stormy, with the live volatility reading, and what Relay is doing: Ready, Trading, or Paused (a loss brake is on).

Market, Confidence, Stop room

The direction it reads, how strongly the timeframes agree, and how much room stops are given right now (wider in a storm).

Trend ride

The open trend trade and its profit, with the marks where the trade becomes safe and where it starts locking in profit.

Range trade, Quick trades, Protection

What the quiet-market engine and the fast engine are doing, and what is protecting the open position.

Today, This month, All time, Win rate

Results at a glance.

Loss brake, Next size up

How much of today's loss allowance is used, and the balance at which the lot steps up.

Next news, Status

With the news filter on: the next high-impact event, its countdown in minutes, and the forecast and previous figures. Status says whether anything is blocking trading.

Account card

Broker, login, balance and account type, so a screenshot always tells the full story.

Prop firm info

In prop mode: the daily loss room, the total drawdown room, and the guardian's state (Armed, Day halt, or HALTED (total)).

Last 10 trades

Every result with a plain reason why it ended: Target hit, Stopped out, Trend turned, Push faded, Weekend off.

> **Past trades on the chart**
>
> Entries and exits are drawn on the chart with their results, so a decision can be looked at afterwards instead of reconstructed from the History tab.

HOW IT TRADES

Three engines, and the market picks

Gold does not behave the same way every week, so Relay does not trade it the same way.

THE TREND ENGINE

Rides the move

Joins a sustained move and gives the winner room to run, with an adaptive trail that locks profit as the trade proves itself.

BOLT

The fast engine

When a move lacks conviction it takes the smaller, quicker profit instead of waiting for a target that is not coming.

COVE

The quiet-market engine

Works the conditions the trend engine sits out, instead of forcing a trend trade into a market with no trend in it.

Only one trend position is open at a time, and at most two positions in all: a trend or BOLT trade, plus a COVE trade. In prop mode it is exactly one. There is no grid, no martingale, no averaging down and no recovery multiplier. Every trade is sent with its stop loss in the same request, so no position ever sits on the server without one.

The stop distance follows the volatility the market is actually showing: wider in a storm, tighter in calm conditions. BOLT and COVE can each be switched off, and the input dialog says what that costs before you do it.

HOW IT TRADES

How the lot size is decided

A staircase, not a smooth curve, and never a function of the last trade's result.

With the default *Risk profile* sizing, the lot is, in essence:

```
lot = floor( balance ÷ step ) × minimum lot × signal scale
```

then rounded down to your broker's volume step, never below one minimum lot and never above the maximum. Below the first step the count is taken as one.

The minimum lot is your broker's smallest gold lot, 0.01 on most accounts. On the default **High** profile the step is **500**: a balance of 500 to 999 trades 0.01, 1,000 trades 0.02, 1,500 trades 0.03, and so on. Moving from 999 to 1,000 doubles the lot in one step, which is the most common reason a jump gets noticed.

PROFILE	BALANCE PER MINIMUM LOT
Super Low	10,000
Low	5,000
Medium	1,000
High (default, very high risk)	500 in calm conditions, 400 in a storm
Custom	your own step

In a storm the High step tightens from 500 to 400, so the same balance sits one notch higher: at 2,000 that is 0.04 in calm conditions and 0.05 in a storm, with no change in balance at all. This is deliberate and was measured, not assumed.

Signal scale. A trend trade with all three timeframes agreeing trades at 100% of that size, with two of three at 60%. BOLT trades are halved again: 50%, 30% or 20%. COVE trades at 100%. None of this scaling can act while the lot is already at the broker's minimum: half of 0.01 is still 0.01. Near the 500 minimum most trades therefore run at a flat 0.01, and the conviction scaling only becomes real above about 1,000. That is the honest reason the recommended balance is 1,000 rather than the 500 floor.

> **A broker whose gold minimum is larger than 0.01**
>
> The ladder counts in your broker's minimum lot. Where that minimum is 0.1, the same balance trades ten times the size shown above. Check your symbol's minimum volume before you trade. Percent-of-balance risk also falls back to the broker's minimum lot when the computed size is smaller, and a *Fixed lot* must be at least that minimum or nothing trades.

This is not martingale

Martingale means increasing size after a loss to win it back. The result of the previous trade is not an input to the formula at any point. Size grows only as the account grows, and it steps back down the same staircase if the balance falls. You can check this yourself: set *Detailed log* to true, and every lot calculation prints a line such as `LOT: 0.04 lots | SL 12.35 | risk 2.47% of 2000.00`. A trade taken straight after a loss and one taken after a win, at the same balance, carry the same lot.

If you would rather have no steps at all, set *How the lot size is decided* to *Fixed lot* for a constant size, or to *Percent-of-balance risk* for smooth scaling with the stop distance.

HOW IT TRADES

Built for today's gold market

Relay was built and validated on the XAUUSD market regime of 2025 onward, which is why every backtest in this guide starts on 1 January 2025. Earlier years may test flat or negative, and Relay says so: whenever the Strategy Tester runs a period before 2025, a notice appears in the log, and on the chart in visual mode.

> **If gold's market regime changes, Relay will be re-validated for the new one.**
>
> The protections described below limit how fast damage can happen in a market Relay was not built for. They cannot turn a hostile market into a profitable one.

PROTECTION

Risk control

HARD RISK CAP, 5%

Skips, never shrinks

A trade whose stop would risk more than the set percentage of the balance is not taken. It is not quietly made smaller to fit.

LOSS BRAKES, 3% / 6%

Daily and weekly

New entries stop once the day's, or week's, closed losses reach the set share of the balance, and resume in the next period. Open trades keep their stops. After six losses in a row Relay also pauses for 24 hours.

WEEKEND

Flat before the gap

Relay reads your broker's own published Friday close and goes flat about five hours before it, so no position is carried through the Sunday gap, whatever time zone the server runs in.

EVERY ORDER

Checked before it is sent

An entry the account cannot carry, or whose stops the broker would refuse, is skipped and the reason written to the log, rather than sent to be rejected.

PROTECTION

The news filter

Off by default, and forced on in prop mode. It reads MetaTrader 5's built-in economic calendar, so Relay itself makes no internet request of any kind. You choose the currencies (USD and EUR by default), high impact only or medium and high, how many minutes to block before and after an event (30 and 30), and whether an open trade is closed before the event.

With the filter on, the dashboard shows the next high-impact event: its name from MetaTrader 5's calendar, the wait in total minutes with the same span in brackets (*2285 min (1d 14h)* is one number, not two), and the forecast and previous figures. Inside an event's blackout window the row turns red and reads **News NOW** with the event's name, followed by **Trading halts** with the minutes left, and the actual, forecast and previous figures.

In the Strategy Tester

The MT5 calendar is not available inside the tester, so a backtest runs without the news filter. For retail accounts the filter ships off: measured on an earlier build, it helped in 2025 and hurt in 2026, where drawdown rose from 18% to 28%.

PROTECTION

Prop firm mode

One switch reshapes Relay for funded-account rules.

Turning on *Prop mode* changes three things at once: sizing becomes at most 0.35% risk per trade, the position count is held at one, and the news filter is forced on, including closing an open trade before the news. News gaps are the one thing an equity guardian cannot outrun.

In prop mode only the trend engine trades; BOLT and COVE stay off. A guardian watches your firm's daily loss limit and total drawdown limit with a 1.5% safety buffer: when equity comes within that buffer of a limit it closes everything and halts, for the rest of the day or until Relay is restarted. A price gap larger than the buffer can still go through. The dashboard's prop card shows the three numbers a funded trader lives by: **Day loss room**, **Total DD room**, and **Guardian** (Armed, Day halt, HALTED (total)).

Describe your firm in its own terms

RULE	WHAT TO SET
Daily loss limit	Your firm's daily percentage. Default 5%.
Total drawdown limit	Your firm's total percentage. Default 10%.
Trailing total	On for firms whose total limit trails the equity high-water mark.
Daily limit is a % of	0 = the initial balance (FTMO's rule and the safe default), 1 = the current balance, 2 = whichever is larger. Match your firm's wording exactly: getting this wrong is what breaches accounts.
Restarts	**Read this.** The "initial balance" is the balance when Relay starts on the chart. It is not remembered across a terminal restart, a VPS move or a re-attach, and neither is a halt. Attach Relay at the start of the challenge, and after any restart check that the dashboard's Total DD room still matches your firm's.
Day loss measured from	0 = the balance at the day's start (how FTMO words it), 1 = the highest point reached during the day. The default is 1, the stricter: it can cost a trade, it cannot cost the account.

Daily reset shift	If your firm's day does not start at your broker's midnight, enter the difference in hours, with its sign: **-1** if the firm's day starts one hour after your broker's midnight (FTMO, 00:00 CET, on a broker running EET).

+30.8%	**+5.8%**
2025 on 100,000 USD, equity drawdown 2.7%	1 Jan to 12 Aug 2026, equity drawdown 3.0%

Prop mode at its defaults, IC Markets real ticks, with the developer's news archive loaded in the tester. That archive is not supplied, so your own prop-mode backtest runs without news blocks and will differ. A backtest, not a funded-account record.

REFERENCE

Every input explained

Thirty-four inputs in six groups. Every default is the tested value.

Dozens more values are compiled in rather than placed on the dialog. Many were tested against alternatives that lost money in at least one year, and keeping them off the dialog keeps them out of reach of an accidental change.

1. Trading

INPUT	DEFAULT	WHAT IT DOES
Magic number	`777001`	The ID on Relay's own orders. Change it only if another EA on the account uses the same number.
How the lot size is decided	`Risk profile`	The profile ladder (recommended), percent-of-balance risk, or a fixed lot. The three inputs below each belong to one of these.

Risk profile	`High`	**The risk dial.** Balance per minimum lot: Super Low 10,000, Low 5,000, Medium 1,000, High 500 (400 in a storm), or Custom. High is very high risk; see How the lot size is decided.
Custom step	`250`	Only for the Custom profile: your own balance per minimum lot.
Percent mode: risk per trade	`0.75%`	Only for percent mode: the lot is set so the stop risks this share of the balance.
Fixed mode: lot size	`0.01`	Only for fixed mode. The size never grows.
Dollar gauge symbol	`(auto)`	Leave empty and Relay finds your broker's EURUSD. Type its exact name only if the log says the dollar dial is off.

2. Strategies

INPUT	DEFAULT	WHAT IT DOES
Strategy BOLT	`On`	The fast engine. **Leave it on**: its own results look small, but switching it off was measured to cost 85% of the 2026 test and took drawdown from 7% to 35% (measured on an earlier build).
Strategy COVE	`On`	The quiet-market engine. **Leave it on**: switching it off was measured to cost 30% of the 2026 test year and about double the drawdown (earlier build).
Go flat before the weekend	`On`	Closes everything about five hours before your broker's own published Friday close (19:00 GMT if the broker publishes none).

Take profit sooner in a market going nowhere	`0 (off)`	**Off, and not a proven setting.** In a market that is not travelling, Relay takes profit at a nearer target, set as a share of what the market has actually been travelling. Over a flat stretch (12 Aug to 23 Sep 2026) 0.45 turned -$34.96 into +$99.31 and lifted the win rate from 43.75% to 51.22%; from 1 Jan to 23 Sep 2026 the same setting cost $1,574 and raised drawdown from 15% to 24%, and it cost $1,226 in 2025, because the market also counts as quiet during stretches that were paying. Leave it at 0 unless you would rather grind through flat markets and accept a smaller year.

3. News filter

INPUT	DEFAULT	WHAT IT DOES
Enable news filter	`Off`	Blocks new trades around events and shows the next event on the dashboard. Prop mode forces it on.
High impact only	`On`	Off also blocks medium-impact events, which means more blocked hours.
Currencies to watch	`USD,EUR`	A comma list matched against the calendar.
Block minutes before / after	`30 / 30`	The blackout window around each event.
Also close open trades before news	`Off`	On flattens before events too; it needs *Enable news filter* on. Prop mode does both automatically.

4. Protection

INPUT	DEFAULT	WHAT IT DOES
Daily/weekly loss brake	`On`	The master switch for the two brakes and for the 24-hour pause after six losses in a row. Leave it on.

Max daily loss	`3%`	New entries stop for the day once closed losses reach this. Tightening it to 2 or 2.5% was tested, and lost money while raising drawdown (earlier build).
Max weekly loss	`6%`	The same for the week.
Hard risk cap	`5%`	Any trade whose stop would risk more than this share of the balance is skipped, not shrunk. The last line of defence.

5. Prop firm mode

INPUT	DEFAULT	WHAT IT DOES
Prop mode	`Off`	The one switch: percent sizing, one position, news filter forced on, guardian armed. See Prop firm mode.
Risk per trade	`0.35%`	The validated prop sizing, as a maximum. 0.50% passes recent years but more than halved the long-run safety cushion (earlier build): a dial you may turn, not a default.
The firm's daily loss limit	`5%`	Set to your firm's rule.
The firm's total drawdown limit	`10%`	Set to your firm's rule.
Total limit trails the equity peak	`Off`	On for firms whose total limit trails the high-water mark.
Daily limit is a % of	`0`	0 initial balance (FTMO), 1 current balance, 2 the greater of the two. The initial balance is the balance when Relay starts; see Prop firm mode.
Day loss measured from	`1`	0 the day-start balance (FTMO), 1 the day's peak (stricter).
Daily reset shift	`0`	Hours added to your broker's clock to find the firm's day: -1 for FTMO on an EET broker.

6. Display

INPUT	DEFAULT	WHAT IT DOES
Detailed log	Off	Prints every signal, the decision on it and the full lot calculation in the Experts tab. This is how you audit the sizing yourself. It writes a lot; leave it off for normal running.
Apply the built-in chart theme	On	Relay's dark chart theme. Turn it off to keep your own.
Keep other indicators off the chart	On	Keeps the chart clean for the dashboard.
Show the on-chart dashboard	On	The dashboard described above.
Draw past trades on the chart	On	Entry and exit markers with results. Display only.

REFERENCE

Broker, account and money

TOPIC	RECOMMENDATION
Broker and account	A raw-spread or ECN account with a low gold spread. Relay was developed and tested on IC Markets real tick data. A broker that marks the gold spread up by about $0.20 per ounce costs roughly 4% of a year's profit, by an analytic estimate on an earlier build.
Account settings	USD account, hedging mode (netting accounts are not supported: COVE trades beside the trend engine), leverage 1:500. One chart, nothing else trading the account. The risk profiles are amounts in your account currency.
VPS	Recommended, in your broker's data-centre region, with a round trip of 100 ms or less. In delay stress tests (earlier build) the execution cost at that latency was nil, while a slow home connection cost noticeably in storm periods.

Time zone	Nothing to set. Weekend timing comes from your broker's own published trading session, not from your PC or VPS clock.
Minimum balance	**500 USD.** Relay does not stop below it: it keeps trading the minimum lot, which is then a larger share of the account than was ever tested.
Recommended balance	**1,000 USD.** It opens at 0.02 instead of 0.01, so the signal scaling can act. The honest trade-off: the larger opening size also means a deeper drawdown, in money and in percent. In the stormy 2026 test (earlier build) the 1,000 USD account finished behind the 500 USD one.

REFERENCE

What to expect

The good case and the bad case, measured the same way. All backtests: IC Markets real ticks, default settings, Market build 2.0.

10,000 USD on very high risk settings, 1 Jan 2025 to 29 Sep 2026

824	62.3%	1.66	+121,447	29.6%
trades	closed in profit	profit factor	USD net result	max equity drawdown

PERIOD, 10,000 USD EACH	NET	WON	PROFIT FACTOR	MAX EQUITY DRAWDOWN
2025	+37,248 USD	61.1%	2.20	23.1%
2026, to 29 Sep	+13,247 USD	64.3%	1.42	28.9%

THE 500 USD MINIMUM	NET	TRADES	WON	MAX EQUITY DRAWDOWN
2025	+2,399 USD	461	58.1%	20.7%

2026, to 12 Aug	+2,883 USD	277	62.1%	23.1%	



The Strategy Tester's own report for the same period, run on the developer's terminal. Another terminal's tick data gives slightly different figures (here 833 trades and +116,825 USD); that is normal between brokers and servers.

The bad case is just as real

On the default very high risk settings, equity fell 23% below its peak in 2025 and 29% in 2026, inside years that both ended in profit. If that depth is more than you want, choose a lower profile: Medium trades about half the size of High on the same balance, Low about a tenth. A lower profile is not simply a smaller copy, though: measured on an earlier build, Medium roughly halved returns at a lower profit factor and without the storm step, and at small balances it was not reliably calmer.

A run of several losing trades in a row is ordinary operation, and single losing months happen. Relay never changes its lot size because of a loss. It waits three bars after a losing trade, and pauses new entries for 24 hours after six losses in a row.

A lasting change in gold's character is the real risk. The protections limit how fast the damage can happen; no robot turns a hostile regime into profit. Run a demo first, and judge Relay on months, not days.

All figures are backtests under the stated conditions, not a forecast and not a live record.

REFERENCE

Your first weeks

The part most vendors leave out: what you see first is a handful of trades, and that is a different experience from a year.

MANY SMALL RESULTS

Plenty of trades close near zero

The fast engine takes most of the trades and produces a small share of the money, while a handful of trend trades carry the year. Expect a screen full of small results.

SCRATCHES

Profit that comes back

A trade can show real open profit, have its stop moved to break-even, and still close at almost nothing. It is the price of leaving the big winners alone: every tested way to rescue those scratches cost more on the runners than it saved.

TIMING

When you attach matters

Your first impression is decided largely by when you start, not by the robot. A single trade can carry a month, and someone who attaches a fortnight later may meet only the quiet stretch that follows.

JUDGEMENT

Judge at 60 days, not 8 trades

If a fortnight of small scratches and a couple of stop-outs would make you switch it off, run it on demo for two months first. That decision is better made before your money is involved.

REFERENCE

Support and the log

Questions, bug reports and feature requests reach the developer directly through MQL5 messages or the product's comments. Please include your broker, your account type and the Experts log for the day in question: that is usually enough to answer in one reply.

Lines you may see in the Experts log

LINE	WHAT IT MEANS
`Relay: entry skipped - margin ...`	The account could not carry the trade at its size. Nothing was sent. Check the balance, the leverage and your broker's minimum lot.
`Relay: entry skipped - stop ... too close`	The broker would have refused the stops at that moment, usually because the spread widened at an open. Nothing was sent.
`REGIME NOTICE`	The Strategy Tester is running a period before 2025, outside the market Relay was validated on.
`LOT: ...`	With *Detailed log* on: each lot calculation, so you can audit the sizing.

Risk warning. Trading leveraged products carries a substantial risk of loss and is not suitable for every investor. Past performance, including backtests on real tick data, does not guarantee future results. All figures in this guide are test measurements under stated conditions, not promises of return. You alone are responsible for your trading decisions and for following your broker's and your country's rules. Never trade with money you cannot afford to lose, and run a demo period before any live use.

Relay, developed by Shaikh Sadi. User guide for version 2.0.